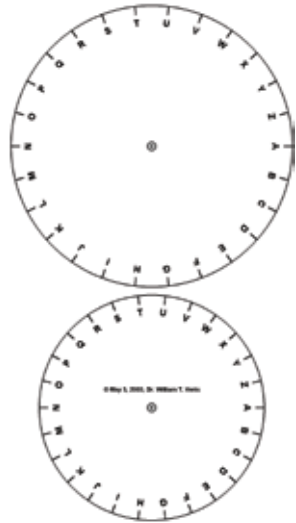


anography, a form of cryptography. Steganography is a form of security through obscurity, or in simple terms, secrets hidden in plain sight. It not just conceals the message but also protects the persons communicating it.

Snatches of cryptography are believed to have been used in the popular Greek epic, the Iliad, especially when Bellerophon was presented before the king with a secret tablet. This tablet informed the king that Bellerophon must be executed. The king tried doing so by having him fight many mythical creatures. But to his chagrin, Bellerophon won every battle.



A caesar cipher

Binary Inspirations

Spartans employed a method called the Skytale (or Scytale) cipher, where a thin sheet of papyrus was wrapped around a staff. Then, the messages were written down all along the staff. The papyrus was then unwrapped. To decode and read the message, the papyrus would need to be wrapped around a staff of an equal diameter. Greek warriors used this technique to communicate. At that time, it was quite effective as only the right staff would yield the message. The Spartan military was believed to have used the Scytale transposition cipher extensively.

Yet another Greek discovered an ingenious cipher. Polybius used a cipher where the letters of the alphabets were arranged in a five-by-five square (the Polybius Square). The letters “I” and “J” occupy the same square. It’s identical to the Playfair technique. The rows and columns are numbered 1 to 5, so every letter has a pair (either in a row or a column). The pairs can now be easily communicated by torches or hand signals. The Polybius Square came into being since it reduced the size of the symbol set. In a way, the Polybius Square can be considered as one of the earliest predecessors to the modern day binary codes.

When In Rome

While the Greeks used cryptography for their military purposes, the Romans were not to be left behind. Julius Caesar discovered a unique way